



THE CLEAR STACK

The AI Stack Playbook

Audit your stack with the 4C Framework

CATALOG · CONSOLIDATE · CONNECT · COACH

A self-audit workbook for operators drowning in software.

How to use this Playbook

This is a working document, not a whitepaper. It walks you through the same four-phase audit a Clear Stack engagement runs — Catalog, Consolidate, Connect, Coach — with the worksheets, question sets, and decision rubrics you need to run it yourself.

Set aside a few hours across one to two weeks. Phase 1 (Catalog) does most of the heavy lifting; the rest builds on what you find there. You can run the whole thing solo, but it works better if you can pull a few colleagues into short interviews — the question sets are included.

WHAT YOU'LL HAVE BY THE END

- A complete, verified inventory of every tool your company pays for — and what each one actually costs per year.
- Your total annual software spend, in one number. Most operators have never seen it.
- A ranked list of what to cut, what to keep, and what to replace — with the savings attached.
- A short list of the manual workflows worth automating first.
- A plan to hand the new, leaner stack to your team so it keeps running.

A note on honesty

This workbook gives you the method. The method is not the hard part — the work is. Cataloging 30+ tools, making the political calls on what to cut, and building the automation that replaces them takes real time and a tolerance for the messy middle. If you get partway in and decide you would rather not run it yourself, that is a perfectly rational conclusion. There is a note at the end about what that path looks like.

The hidden cost of stack sprawl

Software does not arrive all at once. It accumulates. A team buys a tool to solve a problem in Q1. Another team buys a different tool for an overlapping problem in Q3. A new hire brings a favorite from their last job. A free trial quietly converts to an annual contract on a credit card nobody is watching.

Two or three years of this and the picture is predictable: a fast-growing consumer brand running dozens of separate apps, many of them doing the same job, several of them barely used, and almost none of them talking to each other. The cost is not only the line items. It is the time people spend copying data between tools by hand, the reports that take a day to assemble, and the decisions made slowly because the numbers live in six places.

The number nobody knows

Ask a founder or operations lead what their company spends on software each month and you will almost never get an accurate answer. The real figure is scattered across departmental cards, annual renewals, and tools bought and forgotten. Pulling that number into one place is the first and most clarifying thing this Playbook will have you do.

A useful benchmark

Fast-growing consumer and e-commerce brands commonly run 25 to 50 distinct applications across marketing, retention, support, operations, and analytics. Independent stack research consistently finds that 60 to 70 percent of those tools overlap with another tool already in the stack or go largely unused. The duplication is rarely visible from inside any one department — each team only sees its own slice.

You do not need to take that on faith. By the end of Phase 1 you will have your own version of that number, built from your own billing data. That is the moment the rest of this becomes easy: once the waste is visible, the decisions make themselves.

The 4C Framework

Four phases, run in order. Each one produces something concrete that the next one builds on. Skipping ahead is the single most common reason stack-cleanup efforts fail — teams start connecting and automating before they have inventoried what they actually have, and end up automating the mess instead of fixing it.

Phase	What it does	What you end up with
1. Catalog	Build a complete, verified inventory of every tool and what it costs.	A full stack catalog and your total annual spend.
2. Consolidate	Decide what to cut, keep, or replace — and in what order.	A ranked cut / keep / replace plan with savings attached.
3. Connect	Wire the surviving tools together and replace manual work with automation.	A short list of high-value automations, built or scoped.
4. Coach	Hand ownership to your team so the leaner	A handoff package and an owner for

Phase	What it does	What you end up with
	stack keeps running.	every tool and workflow.

The order matters. Catalog before you consolidate, because you cannot cut what you have not found. Consolidate before you connect, because there is no point automating a workflow that runs through a tool you are about to cancel. Connect before you coach, because your team can only own what has been built and documented.

PHASE ONE

Catalog

Goal: a complete, verified inventory of every tool your company uses and pays for — with real costs, real owners, and an honest read on whether each one is actually used.

How to run it

1. Start with the intake questionnaire (next page). Fill in what you already know before talking to anyone. This gets you most of the way to a first draft.
2. Pull billing data. Get the last three months of credit-card statements and any accounts-payable export. This is the step that catches the tools nobody mentions in interviews — the ones bought on a departmental card and forgotten. Billing data does not lie about what is being paid for.
3. Interview each department. Thirty minutes each with whoever leads marketing, retention, support, operations, and finance. Use the standard question set at the end of this Playbook. Same questions every time.
4. Build the catalog. Put every tool into a single spreadsheet with the fields below. One row per tool. Do not stop at the obvious ones — the long tail is where the waste hides.

The Stack Catalog — one row per tool

Capture these fields for every tool. The ones that do the real work are cost, utilization, and the overlap flag — those three columns are what turn a list into a decision.

Field	Why it matters
Tool name	The obvious one.
Category	Marketing, retention, support, ops, analytics, finance, etc. Grouping by category is how overlap becomes visible.
Department owner	Who bought it and who relies on it. Cuts are political; you need to know who to talk to.
Active users	How many people actually log in. Often far fewer than the seats being paid for.
Monthly cost	The exact figure from billing — not the list price, not a guess.
Annual cost	Monthly $\times$ 12, or the annual contract figure. This is the number that adds up.
Contract end date	When you can cancel without penalty. Drives the order of cuts.
Primary use case	What it is actually used for in one sentence. Reveals duplication fast.
Utilization	High / Medium / Low / Unknown. Low utilization plus meaningful cost equals a cut candidate.
Overlap flag	Does another tool in the catalog already do this? The single most valuable column.
Notes	Contracts, dependencies, team attachment — anything that affects whether it can go.

Using AI to speed this up

Once your catalog has real data in it, an AI assistant can compress hours of analysis into minutes. Paste the catalog in and ask it to flag likely redundancy, group tools by overlapping function, and surface candidates that a more general platform or a native integration could absorb. Treat the output as a first draft to pressure-test, not a verdict — you know your business; it does not. But it is very good at spotting the overlap patterns buried in a long list.

Worksheet: Pre-Audit Intake

Fill this in first. Twenty to thirty minutes. It gives you roughly eighty percent of your catalog foundation before you ask anyone else a single question.

1. What is your company's primary industry and main product or service?
2. How many full-time employees do you have?
3. What is your approximate annual revenue range?
4. List every software tool your company pays for that you can think of — do not worry about being complete, just write what comes to mind.
5. Which department or person owns software purchasing decisions?
6. Do you have a centralized IT or ops function, or is software managed department by department?
7. What is your biggest operational frustration right now — the thing that wastes the most time or money?
8. Have you attempted any AI or automation rollout before? What happened?
9. What does success look like for this cleanup in 90 days?
10. Who else should be involved in the audit from your team?

Deliverable for Phase 1

A completed Stack Catalog with every tool, real costs, and your total annual software spend calculated. Do not move on until you have the total number in front of you. That number is the foundation for every decision that follows.

PHASE TWO

Consolidate

Goal: decide what to cut, what to keep, and what to replace — and the order to do it in. Nothing gets cancelled until the decision is made deliberately and signed off by whoever owns the budget.

How to run it

5. Sort your catalog by category. Put every tool next to the others doing similar work. Overlap that was invisible across departments becomes obvious the moment two tools in the same category sit side by side.
6. Find the redundancy pairs. Wherever two or more tools cover the same job, one of them is usually a candidate to go. Look hardest at the categories below.
7. Flag the underused. Any tool with Low utilization and a meaningful annual cost goes on the cut list unless there is a specific reason to keep it.
8. Check what your existing stack already covers. Teams routinely pay for a standalone tool to do something a platform they already own does for free. These are the easiest wins.
9. Score every tool and produce the plan. Use the rubric on the next page. Then write a one-page summary: total savings identified, number of tools cut, projected new monthly spend.

Where overlap hides most often

Across the consumer and e-commerce brands this method is built for, the same overlap patterns show up again and again — described here by function, not brand, because the specific names change but the duplication does not:

- Two or more tools sending customer email and SMS, bought by different teams at different times.
- Multiple support or live-chat tools running in parallel — one for the website, one for social, one a leftover from a previous setup.
- More than one analytics or attribution tool reporting on the same revenue, rarely agreeing, each with its own subscription.
- Several project-management or task tools across departments, none of them the single source of truth.
- Two automation or integration tools doing overlapping work — consolidate to one.
- Standalone scheduling, video, or form tools that a platform you already pay for includes for free.

Worksheet: Cut / Keep / Replace

Run every tool through these questions. The answers point clearly to one of three outcomes.

Ask this	If yes →
Does another tool in the catalog already do this job?	Cut or Replace the weaker of the two.
Is utilization Low and the annual cost meaningful?	Cut, unless a specific contract or dependency blocks it.
Does a platform you already pay for include this capability?	Replace — switch to the included capability.
Is the manual work this tool supports something automation could do?	Replace with an automated workflow (see Phase 3).
Is it essential, well-used, and unique in the stack?	Keep.
Does it own critical data (your core commerce, finance, or customer system)?	Keep — never cut the systems of record. Connect to them instead.

The Consolidation Plan — one page

Pull the decisions into a single summary before you cancel anything:

- Executive summary: total annual savings identified, number of tools cut, projected new monthly spend.
- Cut list: tools to cancel, each with its annual saving and a one-line reason.
- Replace list: tools being replaced by automation or by capability you already own.
- Keep list: essential tools with no overlap — including your systems of record.
- Risk flags: active contracts, data dependencies, and tools a team will fight for. Name them now.
- Sequence: what gets cut first (expiring contracts, zero-dependency tools) and what gets built first.

One rule that prevents disasters

Never cancel a tool that owns institutional data — your core commerce platform, your finance system, your customer database — in the name of consolidation. Those are systems of record. You connect to them; you do not replace them on a cost-cutting pass. Cutting one to save a subscription can cost you the data behind it.

Deliverable for Phase 2

A signed-off Consolidation Plan. Get explicit agreement from whoever owns the budget before a single tool is cancelled. Cuts made without sign-off are how cleanups turn into politics.

PHASE THREE

Connect

Goal: wire the surviving tools together and replace the manual, repetitive work that eats your team's time. This is where a leaner stack becomes a faster one.

How to run it

- 10.** Map where data moves by hand today. Walk each core process and note every point where someone copies information from one tool into another. Those handoffs are your automation targets.
- 11.** Rank by impact. Prioritize the workflows that either touch revenue directly or consume the most hours each week. Build those first.
- 12.** Build one workflow at a time. Automate, test with real data, confirm it works, then move to the next. Resist the urge to automate everything at once.
- 13.** Document every automation. Purpose, what triggers it, what it does, what it produces. Undocumented automation is a liability the day the person who built it is unavailable.

Workflows worth automating first

Across most operations, the same handful of workflows deliver the biggest early return:

- A new lead or signup flowing automatically into your CRM or customer record — no manual entry.
- A status or stage change triggering a notification to the right person or channel.
- A booked call or meeting automatically creating the follow-up tasks that go with it.
- An order, invoice, or payment kicking off the right follow-up sequence.
- Inbound questions routed automatically to the team or person who should handle them.
- Data from several tools aggregated into one scheduled summary, delivered without anyone assembling it by hand.
- A new customer or client triggering an onboarding checklist automatically.

What needs no specialist — and what does

Most modern tools connect to each other through a no-code automation platform without anyone writing code. If both tools you want to connect are supported by your automation platform, it is a configuration task, not an engineering project.

A few situations genuinely call for outside help: custom or legacy systems with no modern way to connect, on-premise software with no cloud connector, and bespoke database work. When you hit one of these, scope it on its own and do not let a single stubborn system stall the rest of the cleanup.

Deliverable for Phase 3

Your priority workflows automated, tested against real data, and documented. Even if you only get the top three built, you have moved the needle — those are usually the ones eating the most time.

PHASE FOUR

Coach

Goal: hand the leaner, connected stack to your team so it keeps running without you holding it together. A cleanup that depends on one person's memory is a cleanup that quietly unravels.

How to run it

14. Train by team, on their own workflows. Short sessions — an hour or so each — focused only on what that team actually touches. Nobody needs the whole system; they need their part of it.
15. Assign an owner to everything. Every surviving tool and every automation gets a named owner who is responsible for it. No owner means no one notices when it breaks.
16. Build the handoff package (below). Write it for the person who will maintain this after you, assuming they were not in the room when it was built.
17. Schedule a 30-day check-in. Catch the small problems before they become the reason someone reverts to the old way of doing things.

The Operations Handoff Package

- The final Stack Catalog, reflecting every cut and change made during the cleanup.
- Documentation for every automation: what it does, what triggers it, what it produces.
- A named owner for each tool and each workflow.
- An escalation path — who to contact when something breaks.
- A renewal calendar with every contract end date flagged, so spend creep cannot sneak back in.
- A plain-English quick-reference for the five workflows your team relies on most.

Keeping it from creeping back

Stack sprawl is not a one-time problem; it regrows. A standing habit prevents the slow return: a quarterly stack review where someone checks for new tools bought outside the process, subscriptions that crept in, and any new overlap. Fifteen minutes a quarter protects months of cleanup.

Deliverable for Phase 4

A trained team, a named owner for every tool and workflow, and a handoff package that lets the stack run without you. That is what makes the savings permanent instead of temporary.

Worksheet: Department Interview

Run this with each team lead during Phase 1. Thirty minutes. Same eight questions every time — consistency is what lets you compare answers across departments and spot the overlap.

1. What tools does your team use every day?
2. What tools does your team pay for but rarely use?
3. What manual, repetitive work does your team do that feels like it should be automated?
4. What data do you wish you had access to that you currently do not?
5. What is the single biggest time-waster in your team's workflow?
6. Are there tools other teams use that you wish you had access to?
7. Are you paying for anything that another team also pays for separately?
8. If you could remove one piece of software tomorrow without losing capability, what would it be?

When to run it yourself — and when not to

If you have read this far, you have everything you need to run a real audit. The framework is not a secret and the worksheets are yours to use. Plenty of capable operators take this and run it well.

It is also fair to be honest about the work. Cataloging dozens of tools and chasing down their real costs is tedious. The consolidation calls are political — someone always loves the tool you want to cut. And building the automation layer well, so it is reliable and documented rather than a fragile set of shortcuts, takes both time and judgment. None of it is beyond a sharp internal team. But it is real work, and it competes with everything else on your plate.

If you get into it and decide your time is better spent elsewhere, that is exactly the point at which a done-for-you engagement makes sense — someone runs all four phases for you, builds and documents the automation, and hands you a leaner stack your team owns. That is what The Clear Stack does.

If you'd rather have it done for you

The Clear Stack runs the full 4C engagement for consumer and e-commerce brands — catalog, consolidation, the automation build, and the handoff — working directly with whoever owns your operations.

Start a conversation at theclearstack.com.